

Freedom in the Cloud: Tribute to Julian Assange, Manning and Edward Snowden

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Freedom in the Cloud – A Tribute to Julian Assange, Edward Snowden, and Manning

Freedom in the Cloud unfolds as an expansive field of sky, composed of nearly half a million, glazed ceramic tiles. The work, monumental in scale yet minute in its construction, transforms a familiar image of the open sky into a pixelated surface — a digital landscape painstakingly rendered through an ancient craft. The material choice itself becomes a conceptual gesture: the durability and earthiness of fired clay are mobilized to represent the ephemeral architecture of the “cloud,” that immaterial space where the world’s data, communications, and memories are now suspended.

From a distance, the image reads as a tranquil skyscape — blue expanse, drifting clouds, and a dark atmospheric band. But as the viewer approaches, the illusion dissolves into a matrix of discrete tiles, each functioning like a pixel in a digital image. This fragmentation draws attention to the constructed nature of both digital vision and political transparency: the surface of the world, or of truth, is no longer seamless but composed of millions of coded fragments, each dependent on systems of control, encryption, and access.

The work’s dedication to Julian Assange, Edward Snowden, and Chelsea Manning situates it squarely within the discourse of surveillance, freedom, and dissent in the 21st century. These figures, who revealed the hidden architectures of global information systems, embody the paradox at the heart of digital modernity: that the very technologies promising freedom and connection also produce unprecedented mechanisms of control and exposure. The title, *Freedom in the Cloud*, therefore, is deeply ironic — invoking both the utopian rhetoric of the internet age and its shadow side of perpetual surveillance and loss of privacy.

By translating the digital “cloud” into a tactile mosaic, the artist performs a reversal — returning the virtual to the material, the instantaneous to the slow, the invisible to the visible. The work’s labour-intensive process, the repetitive placement of tiny tiles, contrasts sharply with the frictionless flow of data and images across screens. This tension between craft and code, between hand and algorithm, underscores the work’s critical stance toward the ideology of seamless digital freedom.

As Slavoj Žižek has remarked, the “cloud” represents both the illusion of infinite access and a form of invisible enclosure — a new condition of dependency masked as openness. In this context, *Freedom in the Cloud* may be read as an allegory of contemporary existence: a vast, alluring surface of freedom, constructed upon systems of surveillance, power, and control. Yet, through its beauty and material persistence, the work also reclaims the possibility of resistance — the slow, human act of making as an assertion of freedom in itself.

The mosaic sky thus oscillates between transcendence and entrapment, between the infinite and the coded. It is a sky that both belongs to everyone and is owned by no one — a reminder that even in the age of the cloud, freedom must be continually reimagined and remade.



Title: Freedom in the Cloud: Tribute to Julian Assange, Manning & Edward Snowden

Medium: Ceramic tile 2mm

Size: 108" x 240"

Year: 2013